

“THEATRE OF THE PEOPLE, BY THE PEOPLE AND FOR THE PEOPLE”: A COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS OF KANO AND IBADAN THEATRE FOR DEVELOPMENT INTERVENTIONS

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Abstract

Theatre for Development (TfD) is a globally recognised theatre approach that deviates from conventional theatre modes, in that it considers theatre as an instrument the marginalised can utilise in their pursuit of social change. The process of materialising a TfD intervention is intertwined with techniques that encourage the active participation of marginalised people in the community to achieve sustainable development. This study comparatively analyses two selected Theatre for Development interventions from Bayero University, Kano, and the University of Ibadan, with the aim of establishing the points of convergence and divergence, and equally uncovering the pitfalls of both TfD interventions. As a practice-led ethnographic research, the study utilised interviews, focus-group discussions, and participant observation to collect relevant data, which unearth the processes followed in the conduct of the two selected TfD interventions. This study, therefore, argues that the impact of a TfD primarily lies in its process, especially when the people are ultimately involved from the beginning to the end. Meanwhile, the study discovers that both interventions involved the targeted people; however, the Ibadan experience did not involve the Beyond Parental Control minors in the ideation and scenario-building stages. Also, there was no follow-up action in both interventions, and the 'spect-actor' technique was not considered. The study maintains that TfD interventions in Nigeria, especially in the academia, have to augment their participatory approach with the 'spect-actor' technique, and need to factor in 'follow-up action' in their framework so that the impacts of the interventions can be measured accordingly. To also avoid engendering wrong methodological conviction on students, who are potential TfD practitioners, efforts should be made to rejig the curriculum to allow a set of students work on a TfD project from their second year through to the final year so that appropriate follow-up action can be effectuated.

Keywords: *Theatre for Development, participation, approaches, Kano, Ibadan, intervention, community*

Introduction

Over the years, the engagement of theatre beyond the walls of its building has become increasingly popular in Nigeria, further establishing its unmatched relevance to the people (Sulaiman et al., 2025). In this case, people have convenient access to theatrical performances on the street, market square, schools, and other popular locations accessible to them. Notably, the fulcrum of a people's theatre, as described by Ross Kidd, in Ogunbiyi (2014), lies in its inextricable link to organisation, critical thinking, and agency/struggle. The approach is focused on a logical worldview that is laced with dialogue and action, while dwelling on the target people's past experiences as dramatic materials to analyse and strategise future actions. Theatre for Development has been applied in Africa to engage people critically and further provoke their action towards a struggle for change. In Kenya, Ngugi wa Thiong'o collaborated with peasants in Limuru to actualise the performance of Ngaahika Ndendaa (*I will marry when I want*), which

exposed the socioeconomic realities of the downtrodden who were ostensibly oppressed by the thieving minority (Ogunbiyi, 2014). However, owing to the seismic impact of the performance on the people, propelling ideological shift and rebellious reactions, the Kamirithu intervention was banned, leading to Ngugi's exile.

In Nigeria, Etherton used community theatre to communicate governmental policies and projects to farmers and villagers in the Samaru community, instigating action and expressing their thoughts (Sulaiman et al., 2025). The Samaru projects in Ahmadu Bello University cannot be discussed without the mention of Oga Steve Abah, Michael Etherton, and Saliu Bappa, who contributed immensely in realising a plethora of street and community theatre projects in Samaru, where the people's farming and communal issues were explored to unanimously proffer lasting solutions. The development-inclined theatre approach continues to date, and many universities across different states in Nigeria have followed suit. Needless to mention the colossal impact of Wole Soyinka's Guerrilla Unit theatre troupe in the late 70s, where satirical short and improvised performances were taken to the people in Ife to campaign against corruption and other societal ills, albeit it was curtailed untimely due to some speculative threats on the facilitator of the theatre himself. While attempts were also made to instil a community theatre experience at Bayero University in the 1980s, as students and scholars drew on their experiences in various communities to re-enact scenarios towards inciting people's participation in dialogue and struggle, the practice did not last long (Ogunbiyi, 2014).

Today, a potpourri of community theatre, theatre for social change, Theatre for Development interventions, and others, which prioritise the people and their experiences, continue to proliferate thanks to the aegis of various universities like Bayero University, Kano, University of Ibadan, Kwara State University, and many other higher institutions where theatre is taught. However, very limited Theatre for Development interventions adhere to all the key procedures of the practice, jeopardizing the essence and goal of the interventions. This research is, therefore, focused on specified Theatre for Development experiments carried out through Bayero University, Kano and the premiere University of Ibadan, in which this researcher participated. While limited studies have considered a comparative study of academically driven TfD interventions in Nigeria, the study aims to fill a methodological gap which permeates the applied theatre field in Nigeria. As such, it raises questions thus: what are the approaches employed in the selected interventions? What are the areas of similarities and differences in the two interventions? What are the limitations of the selected Theatre for Development interventions?

Methodology

This study adopts the qualitative research design in its presentation, description and comparison of the two Theatre for Development interventions. Evidently, given the ethnographic nature of the research, the researcher employs interviews, focus group discussions, and participant observation to collect data. An ethnographic research is conducted to describe the sociocultural patterns and activities of a targeted people (Osuala, 2013). It is mainly focused on descriptive collection of data, which is further interpreted to extrapolate and reach a conclusion. While this method of research gives room for the adoption of several data gathering tools so as to fathom the essence of such ethnography, the researcher is expected to be immersed in the culture of the

people being studied to ensure an acute observation of such people (Ojebode et al., 2019). This practice-based research juxtaposes two selected TfD interventions, which were materialised together with people in targeted communities. The animateurs (facilitators) of the two interventions, including this researcher, visited the communities and immersed themselves in the people's norms, exploring the issues they faced towards charting a course that sees them conscientized in the line of problem-solving and sustainable development. This overarching objective necessitated the use of interviews and focus groups to collect data pertaining to the issues and the perspectives of the people on them. The focus group especially helped to unearth the pressing issues affecting the people. The study also adopts participant observation, which helps the researcher bank on his firsthand information being one of the animateurs in the two TfD interventions in Kano and Ibadan, respectively.

Theoretical and Conceptual Framework

Theatre as a collaborative art underscores the essence of the audience in its presentation, be it in a theatre building, on the street or in the market. In the conventional Aristotelian theatre, the audience is expected to respect the convention of the performance, such that they suspend disbelief and remain passive from the beginning to the end of the play. The actor is also constrained from breaking the fourth wall, as this would contravene the rule of imagined reality created on the stage. However, the advent of Bertolt Brecht's Alienation Effect, which accentuated the need to instil critical thinking in the audience members so they can question their sociopolitical realities and revolutionise, as it were, gave impetus to the idea of ingraining active participation of the people in the processes that could lead to a radical social change. According to Jonathan (2014), the genesis of what we now know as TfD can be traced to Bertolt Brecht's dramatic theory, alongside other renowned scholars such as Paulo Freire and Augusto Boal whose ideological foreground proliferated in Africa, especially, through the works of African theatre scholars like Ross Kidd, Martin Byram, Michael Etherton, Saliu Bappa, Brian Crow, and Steve Abba.

Etherton (2012) also notes the greatest influence of Brecht's ideas in East Africa because, between the 1960s and 1970s, his works informed the larger parts of theatre studies curricula in major schools like the University of Dar es Salaam, University of Tanzania, and University of Zambia. Brecht's overarching idea here is hinged on popular theatre, which, he believes, should respect the people's participation in the process of development so much so that they take over and decide it. Brecht wants the people to take over the culture, and the initiative, both in art and culture, should be taken from the bourgeoisie so that the people can claim it and fully take control. For Etherton (2012), the people in this case refer to both the subject matter and the audiences in Brecht's plays that consciously rebel against the bourgeoisie. Jonathan (2014) states that TfD sprang from this radical approach to theatre, different from the traditional, conventional theatre, also called literary theatre, which dwells on dialogue to present characters, oftentimes in a language alien to the majority of people, simply because the theatre targets only the learned who are literate enough to decipher the elitist drama. It was on this note that scholars beamed their searchlights on the alternative modes to make drama a more functional activity that caters to the needs of people in the grassroots, using their language and respecting their culture.

In Africa, the idea of performing with, by and for the people is not alien, given the very nature of traditional African theatre, which is steeped in the culture, mores, ritual and tradition of the people. Theatre practice in Africa respects the African and his struggle for survival as evident in its extant folklore, dance, drama, masquerade, pantomimes and many others. In fact, scholars have established the fact that Theatre for Development, in its practical sense, evolved alongside the concept of theatre as such, sharing a similar history. But when one considers the nomenclature of Tfd, it becomes, of course, a novel creation (Jonathan, 2014; Osofisan, 2004). History has it that in the ancient African milieu, theatre was adopted to aid socialisation. In other words, the African theatre tradition was ultimately connected to the lives of the people, especially as communities deployed theatrical performances to reflect their culture, amplify unity and communalism, teach moral values, and mobilise the community for self-help and societal development. One can observe this in the varying African performances such as dances, masquerades, songs, folklore, and storytelling, which served as cultural expressions for the benefit of an entire community (Jonathan, 2014). Over time, despite the sublime and subtle African theatrical form that breeds cultural overtones, the people have yet to realise their capacity to deploy theatre as an instrument to stir revolutionary change in their struggle for survival. Notwithstanding, the evolution and proliferation of the popular theatre campaigns in countries like Zambia, Botswana, Kenya, Ghana, and Nigeria through the works of Ross Kidd, Martin Byram, Ngugi Wa Thiong'o, Michael Etherton, Steve Abah, to mention but a few. This shows that, while the elitist literary theatre dominates the African theatre landscape in the last few decades, the learned who mount the literary theatre performances have also realised the necessity to retrace the very genesis of theatre, as the relativist school espouses, as “first and foremost an experience” (Ogunbiyi, 2014), one that extols and reifies the people's culture.

In the words of Obonguko (n.d.), Paulo Freire's conscientization concept, which seeks to empower the marginalised people through literacy programmes, also greatly informed the conceptualisation of Theatre for Development. Freire revealed the fact that the downtrodden have remained in their poor state because they lost their voice through the 'culture of silence', which they willingly embraced. Notably, this 'culture of silence', according to Freire, is augmented by the education approach called the banking system, whereby students are regarded as 'empty pots' that need to be filled with knowledge. In this case, students are not expected to contribute meaningfully to the pedagogical engagements that ensue in class; but they should sit passively and attentively while they consume pieces of information from their teacher. As stated in Obonguko (n.d.), Freire believes that the poor majority can, however, rejuvenate their lost voice by means of dialogue and impactful education that culminate in critical awareness. This philosophical underpinning, primarily, instigated the conceptualisation of Theatre for Development and its incessant success across the world.

Believing in Freire's ideology and taking a cue from him, Augusto Boal echoed the fact that the people (the oppressed) need to stop being mere spectators in matters that directly affect their lives. The oppressed must assume the central role in deciding their fate, and as such the actor should be rendered a spectator, to allow the people take the centre stage and actively re-enact their stories in the form they so will. This process sabotages the culture of silence and gives the oppressed an opportunity to proactively identify, discuss and critically analyse the problems they grapple with (Akoh, 2020). This process of allowing for the active participation of the

people in the entire development process galvanises collective decision-making among the people. The theatre facilitators and the development experts are not expected to interfere in this decision-making or impose any idea on the people. As Boal (1979) espouses, the theatre, as an instrument, should be handed over to the people so they can wield it in their own right and chart their course without any external influence. Akoh (2020) further explicates how this conscientisation process effortlessly helps the people fathom the nexus between their current state and their oppressors, and then stimulates them to question their status quo.

Needless to say, the people are expected to be involved in every facet of a Tfd intervention, even when determining the means of articulation. However, the major problem bedevilling Tfd today is largely connected to real and active participation. Mda (1993) emphasises the community audience in his definition of community theatre, as he believes that, without the complete participation of the community from the beginning to the end, no participatory theatre experience can be deemed efficacious. It is no longer news, however, that the community's active participation in Tfd has remained limited. While the traditional performance modes of the people are utilised, the theatre-making process is imposed from outside the community (Mda, 1993). A textbook example of this is the Laedza Batanani popular theatre campaign, which was unsuccessful because the community members were sidelined in major stages of the intervention, including scenario building and rehearsal phases, and as such, the campaign led to little action.

Abah (2003, p. 101) accentuates the paramount importance of facilitators who usually commence the Tfd process; however, these experts “must and do yield dominance to the grassroots powers of the problems which the practice interrogates.” In the same vein, the downtrodden also possess a “better semiological grasp” of the aboriginal performance forms Tfd dignifies and dwells on (Abah, 2003). The point is clear: catalysts are only facilitators, and they should remain so. Having probably realised that the people are becoming reticent about issues in their community, allowing oppressors to continue to perpetrate their self-aggrandisement, the facilitators come in and evoke the people's conscientization. This fosters critical thinking and awareness of pressing issues, which the people then seek and attempt to address themselves. Theatre for Development (Tfd) is one of the variants of applied theatre, which is done with, for, or by the people in order to provoke social change and sustainable development, “which usually happens as a result of the internalisation of meanings after engaging in the participatory process” (Adie, 2017, p. 177). Tfd exhibits its potency through its process-inclined approach, such that the participants learn lessons and acquire novel experiences as they participate in creating a theatrical performance from the developmental issues raised.

In this light, one can adduce that the people are central to Tfd as a method of communicating development, and the process which manifests the methodological approach employed. This is especially so because sustainable development requires the inclusiveness of all stakeholders across the board. Hence, when Tfd is conducted in any context, it is imperative to pay rapt attention to the methodological approach employed in inducing participation, as this could affect the materialisation of the goal. More so, in any Theatre for Development intervention, the process is sacrosanct because every stage of Tfd is bedecked with different experiences and lessons that could affect the participants positively or otherwise, as the case may be. While many

research studies have focused on Tfd across different contexts, and also disinterred a series of methodological orientations of different Tfd experiments, the crux of this study is to juxtapose the methodological approaches of Bayero University Tfd experiment in Sumaila, Kano and the University of Ibadan Tfd experiment in Ijokodo, Ibadan, in order to uncover their points of convergence and divergence.

Communing with the people is sanctified in this regard as it allows for easy understanding of the people's world and charting the roadmaps to resolve their problems, since they are involved in the processes. Boal (1979, p. 253) also reiterates the power of the people being at the centre of a Tfd intervention, when he states that:

I believe that all the truly revolutionary theatrical groups should transfer to the people the means of the production in the theatre so that the people themselves may utilize them. The theatre is a weapon, and it is the people who should wield it in other words use it.

Thus, he professes Tfd as the theatre of the people, by the people, and for the people, which points to its invariable relatedness to societal concerns. The Tfd approach has become phenomenal and efficacious in that it takes into consideration the belief system of the people, and their medium in its philosophy, and predicates ultimately on the issues bedevilling the people. While Tfd could be packaged as a product, it could be realised as a process as well. A succinct illustration of Tfd as a product is done by Epskamp (2006, p. 51) as stated below:

Applying Tfd to convey a message is synonymous with, or a direct response to, the diffusion model of development communication in which members of the outside group (government and NGOs) act as experts bringing new ideas and development programmes to the oppressed.

In other words, as a product, Tfd is presented to the people while highlighting the problems the people grapple with in their performance, which could take place in schools, on the streets, market squares, or any public place where people could gather to watch and enjoy the moments. However, there seems to be a lack of sustainable development with Tfd as a product in that it “does not allow for a process engagement with its target people. People whom the development messages are meant for are mere objects who are like dumping grounds from a banking system of education” (Adie, 2017: 178). In this sense, Tfd as an approach is merely a performance knotted with messages for the people to consume. Meanwhile, when Tfd is realised as a process, it involves a meticulous organisation that involves the people in its planning and implementation, so that all hands are on deck to discover issues, brainstorm them, and proffer lasting remedies to them. Adie (2015) explains that there are elements that should be incorporated in a Tfd as a process, and they include research, action, participation, and education. It becomes evident, then, that Tfd should not just disseminate information, but empower people, make them own their worlds and decide their fates at their will. The crux of this study is a juxtaposition of Tfd interventions in Kano and Ibadan, paying particular attention to the approaches deployed in the two selected interventions. As such, the work adopts the practical Tfd framework propagated by Kidd (1981) and Hagher (2000) to uncover the points of convergence and divergence, and the gaps in either or both experiments. These theorists proclaim that the approaches for Theatre for Development experiments should be predicated on

data collection, data analysis, scenario building, dramatisation, evaluation, and follow-up action, which influences the comparison of the two Tfd interventions under study.

Case Study One: Kano Tfd Intervention

The 2019 Sumaila Theatre for Development (Tfd) exercise was carried out by the 300- and 400-level students of the Department of Theatre and Performing Arts, Bayero University, Kano. It was a 5-day intervention which began on the 6th of July and ended on the 11th of July, 2019. The exercise was not carried out by the students of the Department alone, but also included about four lecturers. Essentially, the Tfd exercise was necessary to enable the students have an experiential learning of the course, as they had been exposed to the theoretical aspect of it. Although the Tfd experiment was particularly designed for the 300-level students who were doing Theatre for Development as a course, the 400-level students were also part of the experience because they went to the same village to acquire experiential learning on the course, Development Communication, which also requires a field work to gain adequate knowledge and broaden their horizons. However, on getting to the community, all the students from both levels were merged to carry out their various field work exercises by paying careful attention to the different tools and models learned in class.

The Tfd exercise began immediately after the students and lecturers arrived at the Sumaila community in Kano. The students, including this researcher, visited the gatekeepers of the community to pay homage and inform them about the Tfd exercise intended to be carried out in the community. Thereafter, on the second day, we engaged in a transect walk around the community, familiarising ourselves with many popular and respected places in the community. While walking around the community, a community member who led us around the community mentioned names of some places like the dam, the river, the stream, and even the market of the community, narrating the history and relevance of those places to the community. We listened carefully and jotted down key points related to the historical background of those places.

On the third day, the students conducted interviews with members of the community in order to uncover the prominent issues. The community members cooperated with the students as they mentioned almost all the issues in the community. Most of these issues were related to health, unemployment, the laziness of the youth, and poverty. It was also discovered that most of the community members depended on farming to fend for themselves and their families. After that, the students returned to their temporary abode and designed an improvisation which revolved around the issues discovered from the community members, and rehearsed for about two days to prepare for the final performance. During the rehearsal process, a community member who is also a theatre practitioner rehearsed with the students, so that the issues are accurately presented and to also ensure the inclusion of the people in the performance. On performance day, the students created awareness with songs and light dances, which drew the attention of the people, at the front of the community palace (Gidan Sarki). So, having gathered enough people, the Joker began by introducing the performance and establishing how the involvement of the audience was important at any point. The performance emphasised the issue of personal hygiene, poverty, and unemployment. There were series of diffuse reactions on the part of the people during the performance, especially because they could easily relate to the scenarios that were presented. The performance was deliberately left open-ended, and this triggered

immediate comments from the community members who shared their thoughts on the issues projected.

Case Study Two: Ibadan TfD Intervention

The Ibadan Theatre for Development intervention held in July 2023 and the goal was to largely address behavioural problems among the minors using theatre as a tool. The intervention factored in teaching of morals to minimise the instinct for stealing; the establishment of loyalty towards parents and guardians; associating with good friends; and encouraging the teamwork spirit among the minors to reduce their hatred for fellow humans. The Theatre for Development animateurs, who were postgraduate students of the University of Ibadan, embarked on the project in Ijokodo, Ibadan, as an intervention strategy for rehabilitation and engendering acceptable behaviours in society. The facilitators deployed a migratory method by meeting the minors at the juvenile correctional facility to engage them in the TfD experiment, which spanned two weeks.

The Juvenile Correctional Facility in Ijokodo houses many children, teenagers and adolescents who are either imprisoned or brought there to receive care and support. There are those called juveniles who committed certain crimes and found themselves in the facility; the ones called beyond parental control were brought to the facility because their family and relatives could not handle or control them. Also, within the correctional facility, some infants were abandoned and found under the bridge, children whose parents have died or cannot be found, and some other physically disabled individuals. The beyond-parental-control minors were the target of the Theatre for Development project. The minors have different cases of stealing, violence, lack of parental guidance, physical abuse, and some other condemnable acts, which led them to the correctional facility.

Basking in the proximity of the University of Ibadan to the facility, the animateurs had the leisure of time and easy access to the targeted people. They submitted a letter to the facility management seeking their approval for the Theatre for Development intervention with the delinquents. Once approved, the facilitators did their transect walk the same day and also interviewed the beyond parental control (BPC) minors to uncover their issues, which helped to quickly ascertain the materials to work with. Subsequently, the facilitators fully engaged the BPC minors and rehearsed many times before presenting their performance to the rest of the people within the facility, including the management.

Comparative Analysis and Discussion

The 2019 TfD exercise in Sumaila, Kano, deployed the homestead approach to actualise the intervention. This homestead approach required that the practitioners live in the community for several days and interact with the people to acquaint them with the culture and customs of the community. The facilitators, during the 2019 TfD exercise in Sumaila, lived in the community, ate the people's food, drank and used their water, and interacted with them for five days. This was necessary so that the animateurs would not only hear what the people are facing, but also feel what the people were feeling in the community. Contrarily, the 2023 Theatre for Development intervention in Ijokodo, Ibadan, adopted a migratory approach, which required the facilitators to move to and fro the facility. This approach was adopted because the facility management had no provision for the theatre practitioners to domicile there, and also because the facilitators were

acquainted with the culture and tradition of the people, the migratory approach was not a problem for the experiment. In addition, the postgraduate students found it easy to move from the University of Ibadan to the facility in Ijokodo at any scheduled time.

Research

In a Theatre for Development experiment, data collection lies at the heart of research, as it provides the necessary foundation for drawing meaningful conclusions. During the 2023 TfD experiment in Ibadan, the facilitators adopted qualitative methods in collecting data in order to enhance the effectiveness of the data collection process. These methods encompassed interviews, focus group discussions, and participatory observation techniques. As a result of the management's limitations on photography and videography, there were no visual documentations for the project. The major issues discovered at the correctional facility were stealing, violence, lack of parental guidance, and physical abuse. In the same vein, the 2019 TfD experiment in Sumaila, Kano, also employed a qualitative method which involved interviews, journaling and participatory data collection in order to get acclimatised with the issues affecting the people. The theatre professionals discovered many community issues but leveraged on the pressing ones, such as lack of personal hygiene, poverty and unemployment.

Reporting Back

This stage of the Theatre for Development experiment is when the facilitators return to their base after collecting necessary data for analysis. According to Asante and Yirenkyi (2018), the facilitators are expected to leverage the pressing issues identified in the field to craft a drama around them. It is important to determine the issues to prioritise over others and determine their chronology in terms of which comes first before another, and which deserves preferential treatment. Meanwhile, the felt needs of the people must be addressed to avoid apathy on the part of the people. The TfD experiment in Ibadan deployed the indigenous language, Yoruba, to collect data, which facilitated their ability to relate to the minors' issues more. This also occurred at the TfD experiment in Kano, where the facilitators leveraged Hausa to collect data. This eased analysis of the pressing issues and their chronological treatment within the performance.

It is important to note that during the 2023 Theatre for Development exercise in Ijokodo, Ibadan, the facilitators reported back for data analysis, but this was done without including the minors in determining the pressing issues. Rather, the facilitators decided on the prioritisation of the issues themselves on the University of Ibadan campus, where the postgraduate students converge for discussion. However, the 2019 Theatre for Development in Sumaila, Kano, included the people in their data analysis to determine the pressing issues for the experiment. During this experience in Kano, the facilitators collaborated with the community theatre troupe because of their acquaintance with the people and the issues bedevilling the community.

Story Creation

Creating the story is bound to be fictitious, but emphasis is often placed on the reality of the people and the community so that the targeted people can relate to the drama and ensure their active participation throughout the performance. This is expectedly facilitated by the inclusion of the people in the prioritisation of issues during the analysis phase, where the most pressing issues are scaled accordingly. Here, in creating the story for the TfD performance, facilitators

invariably leverage the pressing issues, which in the case of the Ibadan experiment were stealing and violence, while in Kano, they were lack of personal hygiene, and unemployment.

While the TfD experiment in Ibadan did not include the minors in creating the story, the Kano experiment allowed some select community people influence the story creation. In Ibadan, the theatre professionals had determined the story themselves because they felt the minors were not experienced enough to decide on the storyline, which could have affected the interests of some of the minors during the whole exercise. However, in Kano, the people were involved so that the practitioners could be certain they were dealing with issues that were capable of spurring the community people into active participation.

Rehearsing the Play

Having created sketches and scenarios for the TfD performance, it is pertinent to now delve into full preparation for the performance, which is when rehearsal begins. Here, the TfD facilitators are expected to schedule their rehearsal, factoring in the community members. This should be when the community members would be available for rehearsal, especially during their leisure times, though the facilitators have to expatiate the timeframe and nature of the project. This phase is imperative because community members will have the opportunity to make some comments which the facilitators could adopt for proper adjustments of the play (Asante and Yirenkyi, 2018). Although a TfD play is improvised, it is crucial to sustain the themes and scenarios created for better communication between the performers and the spectators.

In the 2023 TfD exercise in Ibadan, the facilitators met with the minors at the facility to decide on the schedule of the rehearsals and the venue. After reaching an agreement, the facilitators started the rehearsal by casting the minors in the play based on the interest shown by each of them (the minors). All the minors were given roles to play, even up to the drummers. The rehearsal period lasted for three meetings with the minors, and it is interesting to note that the minors developed a serious interest in the drama as they would rehearse among themselves when the professionals were not around, which helped to streamline the plot and prepare the drama for performance. Meanwhile, it was somewhat demanding for the facilitators to direct the minors who had no acting experience, but with incessant corrections and collaborations, the minors tried their utmost on the improvisation; moreover, the adoption of the indigenous language made it easy for them to fit in. While the minors were allowed to give life to the scenarios created, the facilitators directed them to ensure they did not deviate from the themes of the play. In the same vein, although the 2019 TfD exercise in Kano also included community members in the rehearsal phase, most of the roles were taken by the students. While the students played most of the lead roles, the community members were cast for secondary roles. During the 2-day rehearsals, the participating community members made some important comments to the storyline, which the facilitators leveraged for proper adjustment of the performance.

Dramatization

On the last day of the 2019 TfD exercise in Kano, the facilitators went to an open space at the front of the community palace (Gidan Sarki) and mobilised people for the performance. On getting to the performance ground, singing, drumming and dancing, community members, which included the old, young, male and female, began to troop out to see the performance. The

performance lasted for about 15 minutes and emphasised some themes like personal hygiene, poverty and unemployment. The Sumaila experience used the Joker system to also drive spectators' attention to the performance and especially the storyline, and how their participation was key to the whole process.

In a similar vein, at the 2023 TfD exercise in Ibadan, having determined the venue for the performance within the correctional facility, an open space, the minors were informed about the performance. Hence, the minors informed others in the correctional home to gather for the performance, while drumming was equally used to attract the audience to the performance space. The performance commenced with the use of music and dance, and the songs used were highly popular as the spectators enthusiastically joined in singing. This aided the interest and participation of the spectators in the performance. The Joker entered the stage at the beginning to set the pace for the performance and relate the issue in the performance to the audience in a funny but succinct manner. As the performance progressed, instead of having the Joker return to relate with the audience, one of the performers left his character to ask the audience questions, which the spectators responded to immediately. This reinforced the spectators' avid interest in contributing to the performance and bridged the gap between them and the performers.

Post-Performance Discussion and Evaluation

After the TfD performance in Kano, the audience members were engaged in a post-performance discussion. This lasted for about an hour, where members of the Sumaila community commented on the performance and suggested some ways the people could solve their problems. One of the community members emphasised the need for them to mobilise one another for sanitation every week to tidy their environment and reduce diseases in their community. Many of the community members were allowed to express themselves and contribute to the development of their community. On the following day, the TfD facilitators left the Sumaila community for their campus (Bayero University Kano) in Kano city.

Also, in Ibadan, the TfD experience was not done without the participation of the spectators in the post-performance discussion as they showed unflinching interest in the issues raised in the performance. Bearing in mind the long-term transformative power of theatre on the minors, the facilitators were able to involve them in the post-performance discussion and evaluation, where they expressed their concerns and thoughts. The facilitators also allowed the facility staff members to partake in the post-performance discussion, where a staff member maintained that one of the minors had already turned a new leaf and wished the TfD program could be repeated occasionally for more impact. In short, the TfD with minors in Ibadan factored in post-performance evaluation of the experiment to ascertain its impact on the minors.

The Ibadan and Kano TfD interventions apparently deployed different and similar approaches. First, while the migratory approach was adopted in Ibadan, the homestead approach was deployed in Kano, even though the majority of the facilitators could communicate in Hausa and understood the culture. In terms of research, rehearsing the play, dramatisation, and post-performance discussion, the two interventions shared similar approaches, factoring the people into the processes. However, it is inferred from the findings that in reporting back and story creation, the facilitators of the 2023 TfD intervention in Ibadan abandoned the people and

crafted the story themselves after sifting the data collected from the minors. This violates the sanctity of active participation of the people in a TfD intervention. Contrarily, the 2019 TfD in Kano had two community members who brainstormed together with the facilitators in analysing data collected, which led them to the creation of an appealing story from the data. It should be noted that only one actor from the community theatre troupe was assigned a role in the performance.

In furtherance, the Theatre for Development experiments in Kano and Ibadan completely shirked the relevance of follow-up action, which is a pivotal phase of any TfD intervention. Akoh (2020) notes that TfD facilitators are expected to sustain the momentum or emotions instigated beyond the performance context so that genuine social action can be materialised. The follow-up is important because it allows the facilitators to evaluate or measure the essence and impact of the TfD intervention. Perhaps because the two TfD interventions were facilitated by academics, who were only concerned about the project during the period of doing the course. In addressing this, Akoh (2020) maintains that the technical teaching of the practice of TfD across higher institutions of learning is not enough. Such teaching should also incorporate how the communities view development from the prism of a product that is frequently learnt and investigated, while also prioritising how communities provoke action and embrace change as the aftermath of their activities. Akoh believes that the orientation of TfD in academia should be inevitably related to the dogma of participatory action research.

Going by the above, it is evident that even though the Theatre for Development experiments in Kano and Ibadan deployed a participatory approach in their respective interventions, there was a protruding gap in reaffirming the impacts of the interventions on the people since there was no follow-up action in the two experiments. Since TfD is geared towards sustainable development, it is imperative to establish a framework for follow-up action and strictly adhere to it to ensure the people are not left worse off than they were initially.

Implication for TfD Practice in Academia

Results from this study show that the 2023 TfD experience in Ibadan allowed the people to participate in the project, while prioritizing such participation in rehearsals and performance. The implication of this borders on its capacity to conscientise the people and achieve sustainable development, which is the primary goal of TfD interventions. The minors had the opportunity to explore their issues and discuss them boldly to effectuate significant personal and social development. However, the study notes that the 2019 TfD in Kano only included one actor from the community drama troupe, who might not represent the people's issues as necessitated. Ostensibly, the 2023 TfD in Ibadan allowed all the targeted people to partake in the experiment, contrary to what was obtainable in the 2019 TfD in Kano. Meanwhile, the Ibadan experience somewhat limited the participants in the ideation stage, which must have implicated on the issues deemed pressing for the project. Ultimately, the participatory approach deployed in the two selected TfD experiments did not incorporate the forum theatre technique attributed to Augusto Boal. The incorporation of this technique could have allowed the facilitators involve both actors and audience members in the performance, which could have made more impact on the people, and could have incited the people's critical consciousness more.

Given the fact that Tfd practice in Nigeria is largely anchored by academics, as in the case of the two selected cases in this study, it becomes disconcerting that the interventions are each bereft of either of these critical stages: scenario building and follow-up action. These phases are sacrosanct because they help to give the people absolute sense of belonging, and also evaluate the sustainability of the impact. Notably, there are Tfd practices that may focus on creating awareness only, however, the selected cases in this study sought to influence the behaviour of the target people, and as well influence sustainable development. Arguably, Tfd academics in Nigeria find it taxing to complete the process of realizing a profoundly impactful Tfd interventions that provoke sustainable change resulting from the approaches utilized. One may observe that these Tfd interventions are mostly informed and shaped by the need to only complement the theoretical aspect of the course with a practical experience without necessarily acceding to and completing all the stages of an effective Tfd practice. This, as observed in the selected interventions, is largely attached to how universities and colleges of education facilitate practical experiences of Tfd only in the penultimate and final classes. Change, more often than not, is realized from the prism of a follow-up (Akoh, 2020), which allows students fathom the technicalities of measuring and evaluating the impact of their intervention on the target people. It is also uncovered that there is usually a wide gap between town and gown, such that the community members and the visiting students struggle to work together and actualize the Tfd project within the short period often allotted to the intervention. This invariably distorts the idea of staying loyal to the processes of realizing a Tfd intervention as, at one point or the other, the students may not have easy access to the people, while the people may exhibit indifference in brainstorming or scenario building. The oftentimes springs from lack of trust between the people and the animateurs. Akoh (2020) explains that complete and efficient Tfd intervention is a viable endeavour that can irrefutably be galvanized through the academia; meanwhile it must not be confined in the popular approach of creating plays from data gathered from the people, acting and discussing it with the people. The implication of this is that students will be consciously and subconsciously influenced to replicate such segmented approach in their practice as Tfd facilitators upon graduating.

Conclusion

This study juxtaposes the Theatre for Development interventions in Ibadan (2023) and Kano (2019) to uncover the points of convergence and divergence in the approaches deployed in the two experiences. In undertaking the Tfd experiments, the facilitators in Ibadan adopted a migratory approach, while the facilitators in Kano deployed a homestead approach. It is underscored that the two selected Tfd cases followed the some processes of undertaking a Theatre for Development. While the 2023 Tfd in Ibadan disregarded the relevance of the targeted minors' inputs in the analysis and story creation phases, the 2019 Tfd in Kano only allowed one member of the community's drama troupe act in the performance. The two Tfd interventions shirked follow-up action, which is a crucial stage in any Theatre for Development experience when the sustainability of the development issues addressed through Tfd is evaluated and measured. The study maintains that Tfd interventions in Nigeria, especially in the academia, need to factor in "follow-up" in their framework so that the impacts of the interventions can be measured accordingly. Academically, avoiding such a critical stage implicates on the students who liable to practice, upon graduation, with the conviction that follow-up is unnecessary. By implication, in the academia, efforts need to be channeled in ensuring students are practically engaged in a Tfd project from 200 level, for instance, so that

they can have ample time to follow and learn through the varying processes of conducting an effective TfD intervention. Moreover, albeit the 2023 TfD in Ibadan allowed the minors to participate fully in dramatisation, the audience members could be invoked to assume the 'spect-actor' role to further reinforce the internalisation of the issues being explored and achieve sustainability.

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